

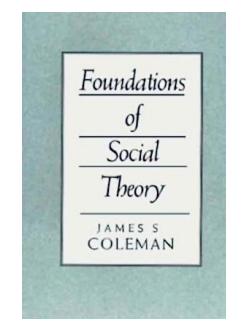
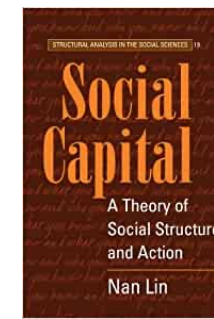
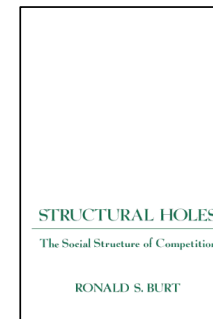
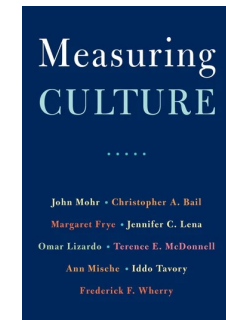
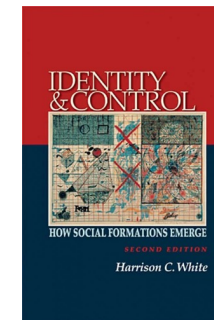
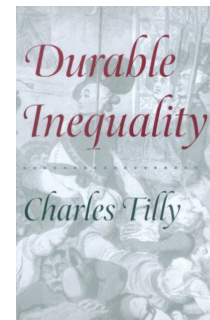
January 2025 | 8.50 am | B-216

Statistical Network Models

Session 2 – Theory

Session 2 – Sociological Network Theories

- Different strands of sociological theory
- Formalist vs. relational accounts
- Multi-paradigmatic perspective



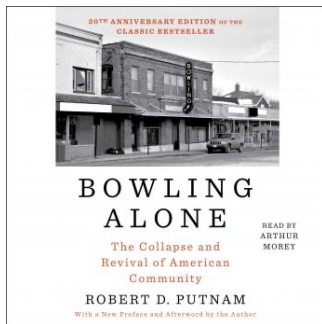
Fuhse (2020)

- What is the contribution of the text by Fuhse?
- Which streams in network theory does Fuhse identify?

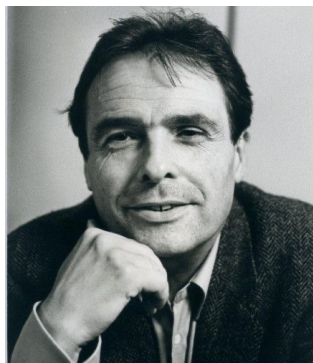
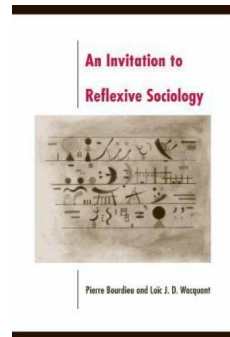
Action Theory and Social Capital

- Individuals can mobilize resources that are present in their personal networks
- Networks and their structure can influence collective outcomes (e.g., solution to free rider problems)
- Certain network positions offer advantages that go beyond the availability of resources (e.g., brokerage positions bridging structural holes)

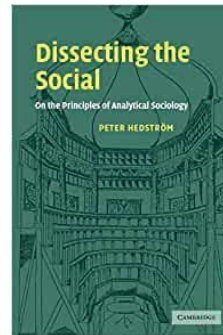
Action Theory and Social Capital



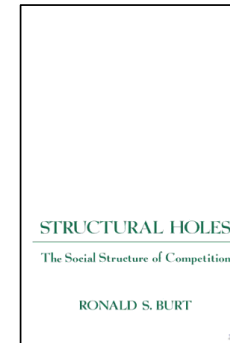
Robert Putnam
1941



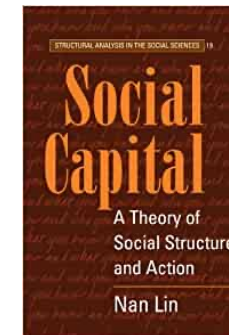
Pierre Bourdieu
1930-2002



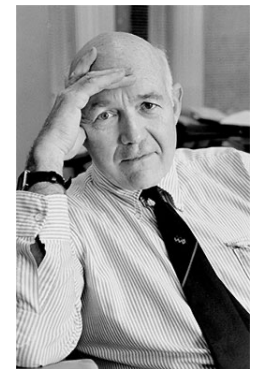
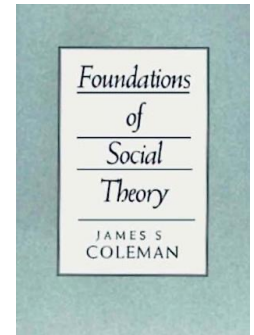
Peter Hedström
~1955



Ronald Burt
1949



Nan Lin
1938



James Coleman
1926–1995

Pragmatism and Interactionism

- Subjective experience of actors is a central aspect of this approach, but what is meant by “subjective experience”?
- Networks as fluid and dynamic structures of meaning, focus on situations and interactions
- Four “pushes”: subjective meaning, processualization, qualitative-interpretive methods, integration of network and field theory

Pragmatism and Interactionism

Manifesto for a Relational Sociology¹

Mustafa Emirbayer
New School for Social Research

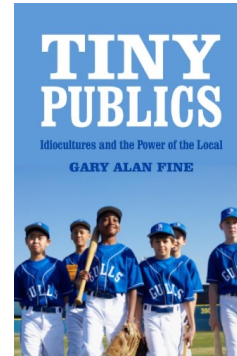
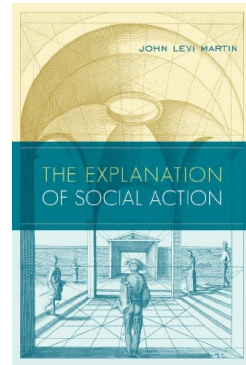
Sociologists today are faced with a fundamental dilemma: whether to conceive of the social world as consisting primarily in substances or processes, in static "things" or in dynamic, unfolding relations. Rational-actor and norm-based models, diverse holism and structuralism, and statistical "variable" analyses continue implicitly or explicitly to prefer the former point of view. By contrast, the "relational" perspective, in its various guises, has been the dominant perspective for both theory and empirical research. In the limited pages, I outline some of the difficulties and challenges now facing relational analysis, taking up in turn the issues of boundaries and entities, network dynamics, causality, and normative implications.

Sociologists today are faced with a fundamental dilemma: whether to conceive of the social world as consisting primarily in substances or in processes, in static "things" or in dynamic, unfolding relations. Large segments of the sociological community continue implicitly or explicitly to prefer the former point of view. Rational-actor and norm-based models, diverse holism and structuralism, and statistical "variable" analyses—all of them beholden to the idea that it is entities that come first and relations among them only subsequently—hold sway throughout much of the discipline. But increasingly, researchers are searching for viable analytic alternatives, approaches that reverse these basic assumptions and depict social reality instead in dynamic, continuous, and processual terms. The purpose of this "manifesto" is to lay out the essential features of this latter point of view. It begins by presenting the relational perspective in broad outlines (by way of a comparison with competing substantialist

¹ I would like to thank Ronald Becker, David Gibson, Jeff Goodwin, Michael Lounsbury, Ann Mittlebach, John Mote, Jeffrey Olick, Shelley Orr, Mimi Shale, Charles Tilly, and Barbara White for their many helpful comments on earlier drafts. I would also like to thank the Social Research, and in the Monthly Discussion Group on Theory and Culture in New York City for their stimulating criticisms and suggestions. Direct correspondence to Mustafa Emirbayer, Department of Sociology, New School for Social Research, 35 Fifth Avenue, New York, New York 10003.

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0022-0675/97/1010-0000\$05.00

AJS Volume 103 Number 2 (September 1997): 281–317 281



Article

Worlds, Fields and Networks: Becker, Bourdieu and the Structures of Social Relations

Wendy Bottero and Nick Crossley
University of Manchester, UK

Abstract

This paper reflects upon Bourdieu's concept of cultural fields, Becker's concept of 'src worlds' and the concept of networks as developed in social network analysis. We challenge the distinction that Bourdieu makes between the objective 'relations' and 'positions' constitutive of 'social space' and visible social relationships. In contrast, we maintain that interaction is generative of social spaces and positions and should be integral to any account of them. Becker's position is better from this perspective, but while Becker refers repeatedly to social networks, he fails to develop the concept or exploit its potential as a means of exploring social structures. Both Becker and Bourdieu have an underdeveloped conception of social connection which weakens their respective conceptions of the space of cultural production. Our proposed remedy is to use social network analysis to derive 'positions' and 'relations' between 'positions', as prioritized by Bourdieu, from data on concrete interactions and relations. This allows 'world' analysis to speak to the issues of field analysis without sacrificing its strengths. We illustrate our case by way of an analysis of two UK music scenes from the late 1970s.

Keywords

art worlds, Becker, Bourdieu, cultural fields, cultural production, social interaction, social networks



Mustafa Emirbayer
~1958



John Levi Martin
1964



Gary Allan Fine
1950



Wendy Bottero
~1962

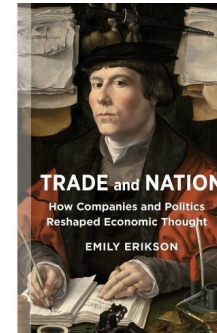
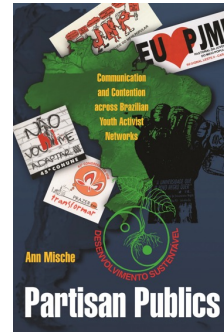
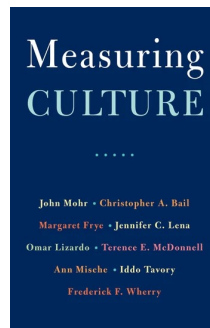
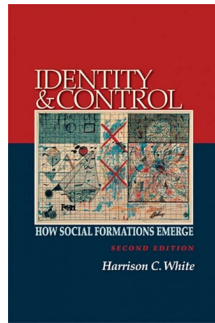
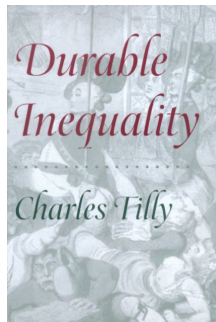


Nick Crossley
~1961

Relational Sociology

- First proponents of relational sociology oriented at structuralist paradigm, i.e., focus on observable social structures not subjective experience of actors
- After “cultural turn” (~1990er) stronger focus on meaning, identities, styles, and stories

Relational Sociology



Networks as Culturally Constituted Processes

A Comparison of Relational Sociology and Actor-network Theory

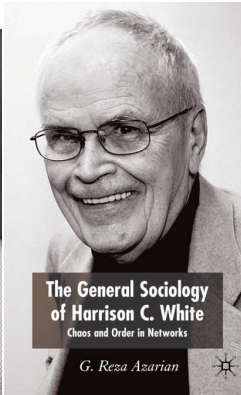
Sophie Mützel
Social Science Research Center, Berlin

abstract: This article connects two current, typically separate strands in network thinking that treat 'culture' and 'structure' as intermingled rather than as autonomous entities of a duality. It reviews and compares two different traditions, the 'cultural turn' in social network analysis and actor-network theory, which both view networks as culturally constituted processes. The article argues that the two approaches share many conceptual similarities, although important differences remain. They differ on what kinds of actors ascribe meaning to others. Furthermore, the article argues that some conceptual similarities have turned into methodological points of convergence in data analysis. The article suggests economic sociology as one possible area of research where the two approaches productively connect.

keywords: actor-network theory ♦ culture ♦ network theory ♦ relational sociology



Charles Tilly
1929-2008



Harrison White
1930-2024



John Mohr
1956-2019



Ann Mische
1965



Emily Erikson
~1975



Sophie Mützel
~1971

Formalist and Relationalist Theory in Social Network Analysis

- What is the contribution of Erikson (2013)?
- Why is it necessary to discuss different traditions in network theory?
- What are sources from which formalist vs. relationalist accounts stem?

Overall comparison between traditions

Formalists

A priori social structures

Kant -> Simmel -> Formalists

More deductive approach

Relationalists

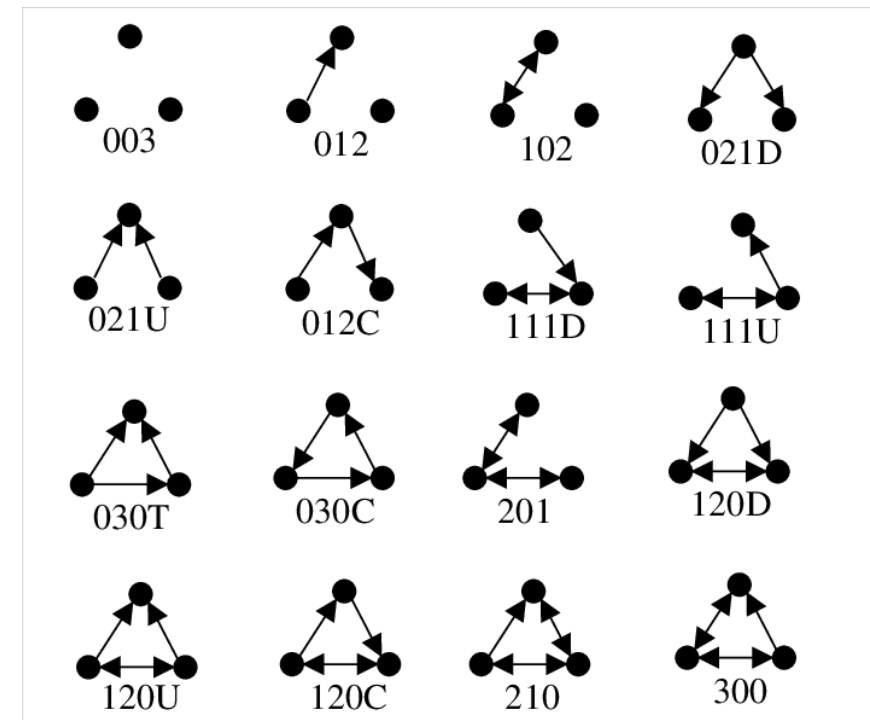
A posteriori

American Pragmatism -> White -> Relationalists

More inductive

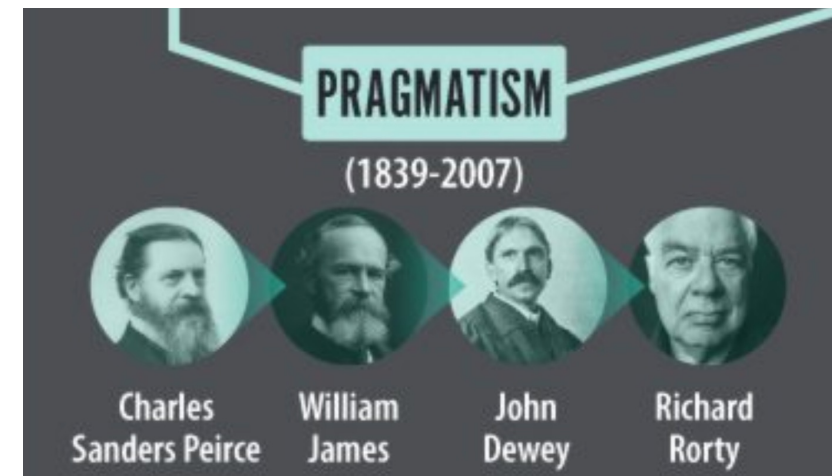
Formalists in greater depth

- What is the role of Kant for Simmel's study of social forms?
- What are example for empirical investigations in the formalist tradition?
- What is the formalist's conceptualization of networks?



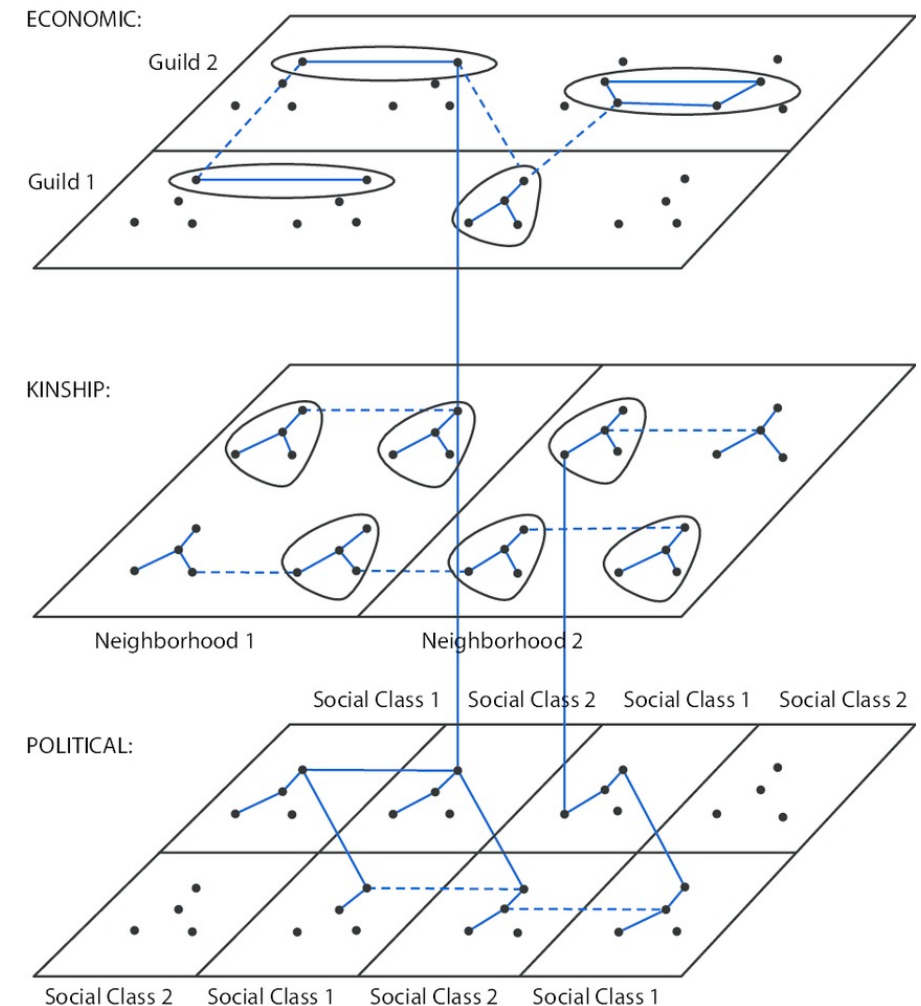
Relationalists in greater depth

- What is the role of American Pragmatism for relationalists?
- What are examples for empirical investigations in the relationalist tradition?
- What is the relationalists conceptualization of networks?



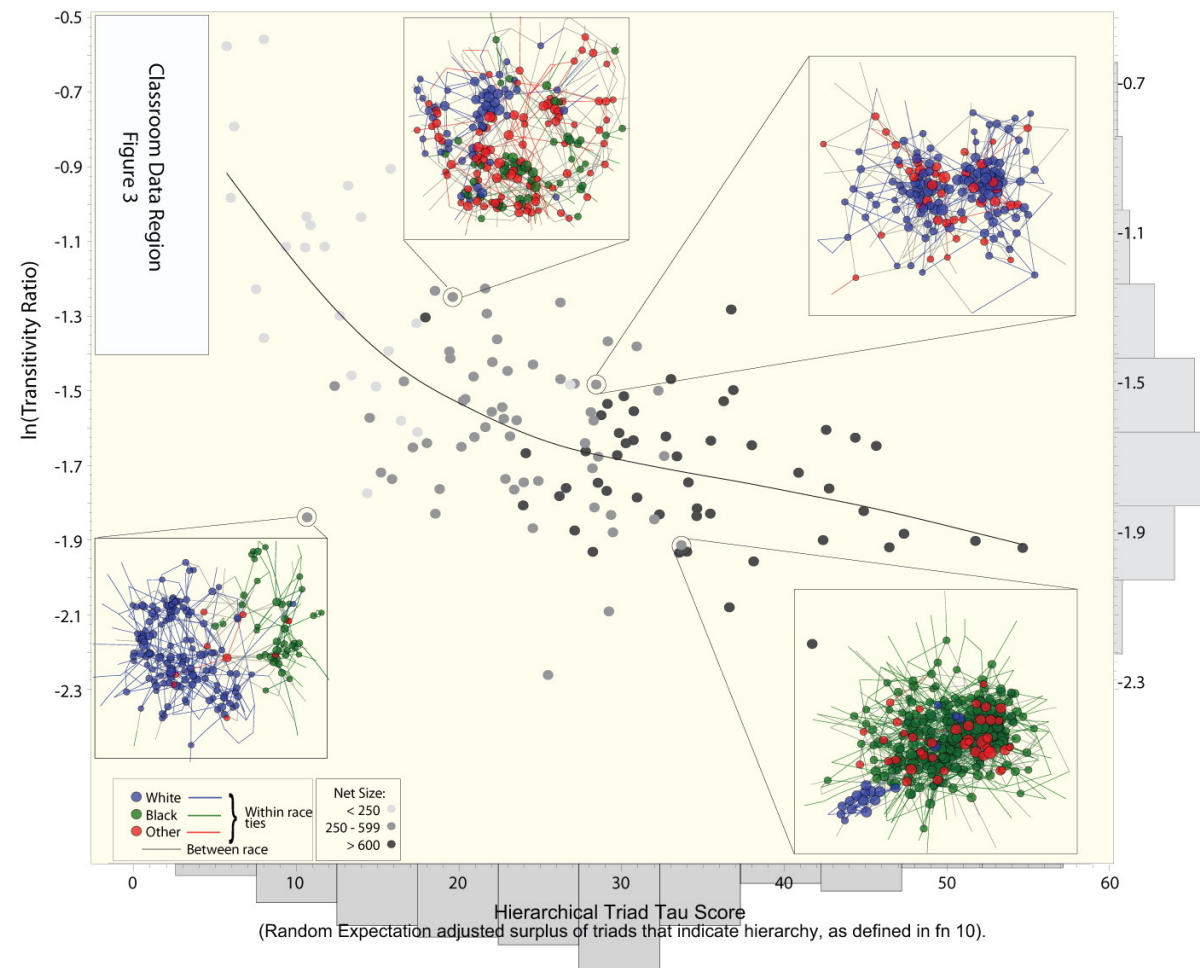
Content of ties

- What is the key differences in how formalists and relationalists think about the content of ties constituting networks?
- In which stream would you place the work of network scientists when it comes to the content of ties?



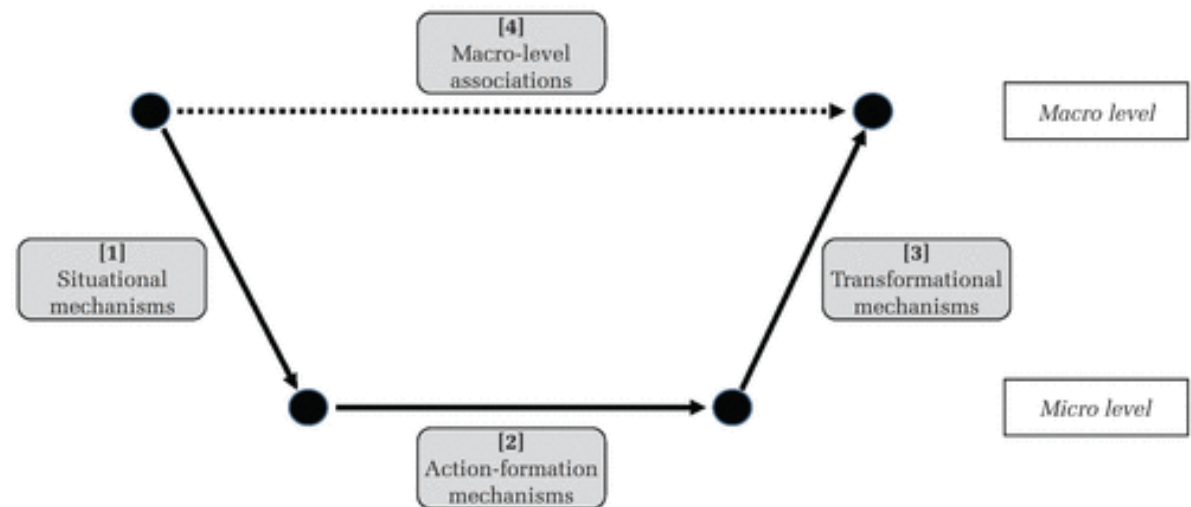
Role of context

- What is the role of context in formalist and relationalist accounts of networks?
- Can you name examples for empirical investigations?



Micro-macro link

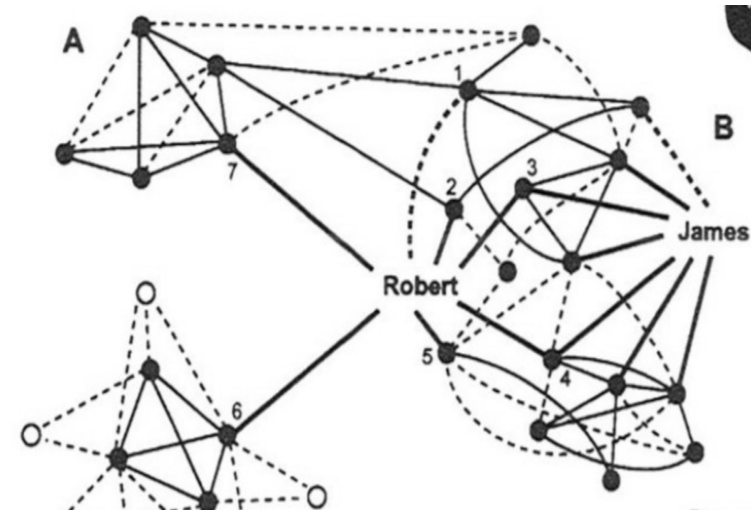
- How do formalists and relationalists accounts deal with the micro-macro link?
- Why are the assumptions on what constitutes an individual or a group so important for the micro-macro problem?



Agency vs. process

What are similarities and differences between formalism and relationalism regarding the question of agency?

Why does Erikson argue that counterintuitively relationalism places a greater emphasis on agency?



Discussion

- Do you think the theoretical categorization of network theories into formalists and relationalists is better than the categories Fuhse provided? (Action theory, Pragmatists, Relational)?
- What is the difference between the two categorizations?
- What is your general take-away of the discussion of different theoretical traditions concerned with networks?

Readings for next week

Lusher, D., Koskinen, J., & Robins, G. (Eds.). (2013). ***Exponential random graph models for social networks: Theory, methods, and applications***. Cambridge University Press. p. 1-46

Optional:

Cranmer, S. J., & Desmarais, B. A. (2011). Inferential network analysis with exponential random graph models. ***Political analysis***, 19(1), 66-86.

Lusher, D., Koskinen, J., & Robins, G. (Eds.). (2013). ***Exponential random graph models for social networks: Theory, methods, and applications***. Cambridge University Press. p. 49-90

Thank you for your attention!